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Amid surveillance concerns, Dearborn approves \$720K for police access to real-time videos

The Fusus program has drawn some criticism from civil liberties advocates who fear monitoring of protesters.



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Detroit Free Press

May 15, 2025 | Updated Feb. 27, 2026, 12:52 a.m. ET

Key Points

Dearborn City Council approves a \$720,000 contract for a surveillance video system with Axon's Fusus.

Civil liberties advocates have expressed concern over whether videos in the Fusus program could target protesters.

Dearborn had more than 80 pro-Palestinian protests from October 2023 to October 2024.

The city of Dearborn will soon unveil a new program with a surveillance company that will allow police to access the video feeds of private businesses and individuals amid concern from civil rights advocates over whether it may target protesters and immigrants.

Dearborn City Council recently unanimously approved \$720,000 for a five-year contract for police to use Axon's Fusus program that gains access to the private camera feeds of businesses and individuals who opt into the program. City officials say the contract will better equip police to [fight and deter crime](#), which has become a campaign issue this year with the mayor and City Council members running for reelection.

The city will use \$133,000 from its drug forfeiture and federal justice funds to help pay for the Fusus system. The University of Michigan-Dearborn is also giving Dearborn money to support the Fusus program, a university spokeswoman said.

Dearborn is believed to be one of the first cities in Michigan to use Fusus; Kalamazoo launched its Fusus program in 2023. It's unclear when exactly the program will formally launch, but it is expected to roll out later this year, a city official said.

"This is a strong benefit for the city of Dearborn," Dearborn Mayor Abdullah Hammoud said at the April 22 council meeting, at which the contract for Fusus was approved.

"This is the cutting edge of technology and law enforcement," Dearborn Police Chief Issa Shahin said at the meeting, echoing Hammoud's views. "It combines the ability to have a live feed of what's happening in real time, not only in a real time crime center, but actually in the police cars in the officers' hands."

While praised by law enforcement officials, the surveillance system has drawn critics from civil liberties advocates who are concerned about privacy and monitoring of groups such as protesters, as President Donald Trump's administration cracks down on pro-Palestinian activists and immigrants. Dearborn has a high percentage of immigrants and frequently has pro-Palestinian protests, with [more than 80 rallies](#) held in America's only Arab-majority city in support of Palestinians from October 2023 to October 2024.

Groups such as the [Electronic Frontier Foundation](#) and some [elected officials](#) have raised concerns about whether Fusus could be used to target immigrants and protesters with views at odds with the Trump administration.

Nashville, Tennessee, Mayor Freddie O'Connell, had initially supported Fusus, but decided in April [to oppose it over concerns](#) with the Trump administration, the Nashville Banner reported. Some immigrants with pro-Palestinian views have been arrested by federal immigrant agents in recent months as U.S. officials said they are cracking down on people they accuse of sympathizing with Hamas and other groups. [A report by Reuters in 2023 raised questions](#) about whether the Fusus system could be used to target political protests.

"We will be revoking the visas and/or green cards of Hamas supporters in America so they can be deported," Secretary of State Marco Rubio said in March after a former

student at Columbia University, active in pro-Palestinian rallies, was arrested by immigration agents.

Shahin said the Fusus program will also allow officers to have a live feed of 911 calls so they can hear the 911 calls directly, helping improve response times and giving officers more information when responding to emergencies. It can help speed up the time it takes for police to get access to video footage: Instead of having to go to the location, the video will already be uploaded to the police department.

In a statement Tuesday, May 13, to the Free Press, Shahin stressed that the program does not include facial recognition technology.

“The safety and security of our residents is the top priority of the Dearborn Police Department,” Shahin said. “This mission has directed our plans to integrate the Fusus Real-Time Crime Center, which provides live video and information during an emergency, to aid our officers in their response. ... The Fusus system is not equipped for the integration of facial recognition technology.”

He added that Fusus “utilizes already existing visual infrastructure previously installed by businesses, community organizations and other groups for on-site security.”

Shahin said police officers visited Kalamazoo and [South Bend](#), Indiana, to study how those cities use Fusus, and that the Atlanta Police Department “overwhelmingly supports” its own Fusus system.

In addition to the planned Fusus system, Dearborn police have recently installed license plate readers and are increasingly using drones.

City Council President Michael Sareini supports the Fusus program, saying at the council meeting: “We’re trying to make our residents safe and more protected. And the bad guys ... they don’t have more rights than we do. ... People live in the city of Dearborn because of our public safety.”

Officials: No expectations of privacy outside

City officials said Dearborn residents should not have expectations of privacy when they're outside their homes.

"There's no expectation of privacy in a public space," said city attorney Jeremy Romer.

"I want to make it abundantly clear: You have no expectations of privacy in the public outside," Sareini said. "If you're walking on the street, you do not have the same privacy you do as if you're inside your home."

The city is still working out the details of implementation, but offered some details on how it would work. Businesses, such as a gas stations, for example, would work directly with [Axon's Fusus](#) to register and then purchase [Fusus devices that would transmit](#) their video footage to the Dearborn Police Department. It's unclear how much it could cost businesses and individuals to use the system. The Electronic Frontier Foundation said it "can cost hundreds of dollars in hardware and subscription costs each month" that are usually paid to Fusus directly. Shahin said the "overwhelmingly majority" of people who opt in to the system would work directly with Axon's Fusus program.

Dearborn City Councilman Ken Paris, a retired Dearborn police officer and commander, expressed some concerns about "transparency and privacy issues" with the Fusus system, but voted in favor of it. During the April 22 meeting, he got into a brief exchange with Sareini and Hammoud. Hammoud said the city has done its "due diligence" for a year in educating businesses and corporations about Fusus.

"We don't do anything in haste," Hammoud said.

Regarding the issue of privacy and surveillance, Hammoud said the city has data policies in place that protect rights.

"We don't own the camera footage," Hammoud said of private surveillance footage. "We do not have the right to copy and download anything without permission."

Axon, which operates Fusus, did not return a message seeking comment.

The University of Michigan-Dearborn is "one of several community partners collaborating with the City of Dearborn to share camera access for public safety incidents," Kristin Palm, a spokeswoman for the university, told the Free Press. "We have learned over the years from numerous tragedies at institutions across the U.S., including here in Michigan, how important it is during critical incidents for agencies to be able to work together and share information in real time when a crisis arises. A one-time investment was made to the City of Dearborn to support these integration efforts."

Civil liberties advocates express concerns

Beryl Lipton, a senior investigative researcher at the Electronic Frontier Foundation who has written extensively about Fusus, said the system is part of a broader effort by Axon to be a one-stop shop for surveillance efforts by police departments.

"They really do want to sort of establish themselves as being like an entire ecosystem of police surveillance technology," Lipton told the Free Press. "And they have historically been able to leverage their existing contracts and relationships in order to push forward additional surveillance tools. ... I think that there's probably going to be a push to adopt additional surveillance technologies or expand the use of existing tech surveillance technologies within the city, because that's just generally the way that this company works."

Lipton said "there's a huge concern around" whether Fusus videos could be used to target protesters. "I think that there's an opportunity for abuse."

The city of Detroit has had a surveillance system called Project Green Light since 2016, but it's different from Fusus in that it has its own system instead of relying on an outside company like Fusus. Some have questioned [whether Project Green Light is effective in reducing crime](#), the Free Press reported earlier. A [study by the Department of Justice](#) released in 2023 said it did not lead to a reduction in violent crime, but did see a reduction in property crimes, the Metro Times reported. On May 11, an activist group,

Amplify Palestine Michigan, [said in](#) an Instagram post that [Dearborn police uses BriefCam](#), a video surveillance software system established in Israel and now owned by Canon; a spokesperson for BriefCam could not be reached for comment.

Councilman: Dearborn a model for protests

Councilman Mustapha Hammoud, who introduced the resolution for the Fusus contract along with Council President Pro Tem Leslie Herrick, told the Free Press this is about taking a “more proactive approach” on helping police with public safety.

“It gives them the tools to do their jobs,” Mustapha Hammoud said.

Mustapha Hammoud mentioned the [2023 killing of Dearborn florist Hassan Salame](#), shot dead in a robbery outside a sushi restaurant, as an example of how technology can help police, saying that license plate readers helped police in that case nab the suspects.

Sareini also mentioned the school shooting in Uvalde, Texas, in 2022 as an example of how police could have better responded if there were real-time video footage. In 2021, Dearborn police started to get [security camera feeds from Dearborn Public Schools](#), which was opposed by some activists.

Mustapha Hammoud said Abdullah Hammoud and Shahin both have been supportive of people's rights to protest. He said Dearborn has been a model for allowing protests, protecting the free speech of immigrants and pro-Palestinian views, with no major incidents.

“It’s a problem in other places,” Mustapha Hammoud said. “It’s not a problem here.”

The South Bend Tribune, Nashville Tennessean and Reuters contributed to this report.

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